

Skills and Academic Offering in Latin America

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Abstract

This work presents a cross-national case study that compares the emphasis on ten basic skills in higher education across 3,155 university programs from 481 universities in nine Latin American countries. We model the emphasis on these basic skills as an undirected bipartite network where basic skills are regarded as means that facilitate learning and a rapid acquisition of knowledge. While descriptive analyses reveal that the academic offering is weakly connected to basic skills, inferential analyses based on exponential random graph estimates confirm that scientific reasoning is consistently the most central skill in Latin American graduate programs. This finding reveals shared educational priorities across the region, with implications for curriculum design and regional development.

Introduction

A challenging decision for any manager is placing the right person in the right job. In his search for predictors of job performance, the American psychologist David C.McClelland [1] argued that academic aptitude, knowledge from content tests, school grades, and credentials are often poor predictors of employee performance. McClelland’s research laid the groundwork for the “job competence assessment” method, which became foundational to management literature in the latter half of the 20th century [2]. Contemporary data-driven research supports McClelland’s findings, suggesting that academic offerings often fall short of meeting companies’ job requirements [3]. In this context, gaining a competitive advantage from a labor perspective increasingly relies on improving the educational-occupational match [4]. Some scholars argue that one way to enhance this education-job alignment is by estimating the value of employees’ skills, especially given the unpredictable future [5].

A list

- Item 1 15
- Item 2 16

References 17

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19
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27